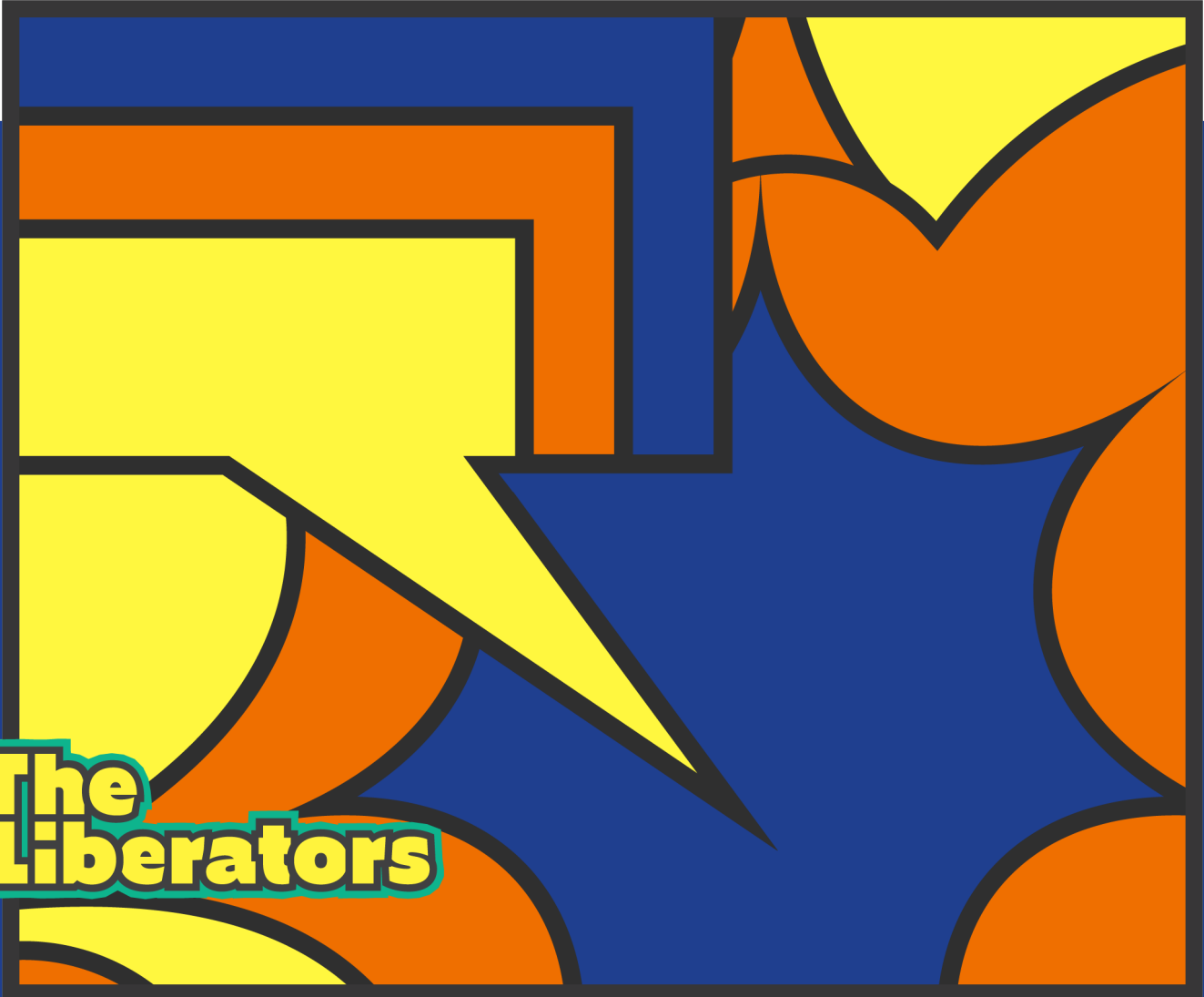


Discover The Roots Of Conflict With Pinch Theory

A do-it-yourself workshop to learn how conflict builds over time, and how clarifying roles and expectations can help navigate them.



**The
Liberators**

The Purpose Of This Workshop

Hey there,

Our brains are incredible organs, allowing complex emotions, thoughts, and creative solutions. Although they're doing a good job of keeping up with how our modern lives have changed, they still retain many of the qualities that helped us survive millions of years ago.

Seeking safety in groups, our brains have evolved a deep sensitivity to social hierarchy and what is happening in our interactions with others. Our social nature gives us a strong innate need to be seen and heard by others, to belong to a group, and to be treated fairly compared to others.

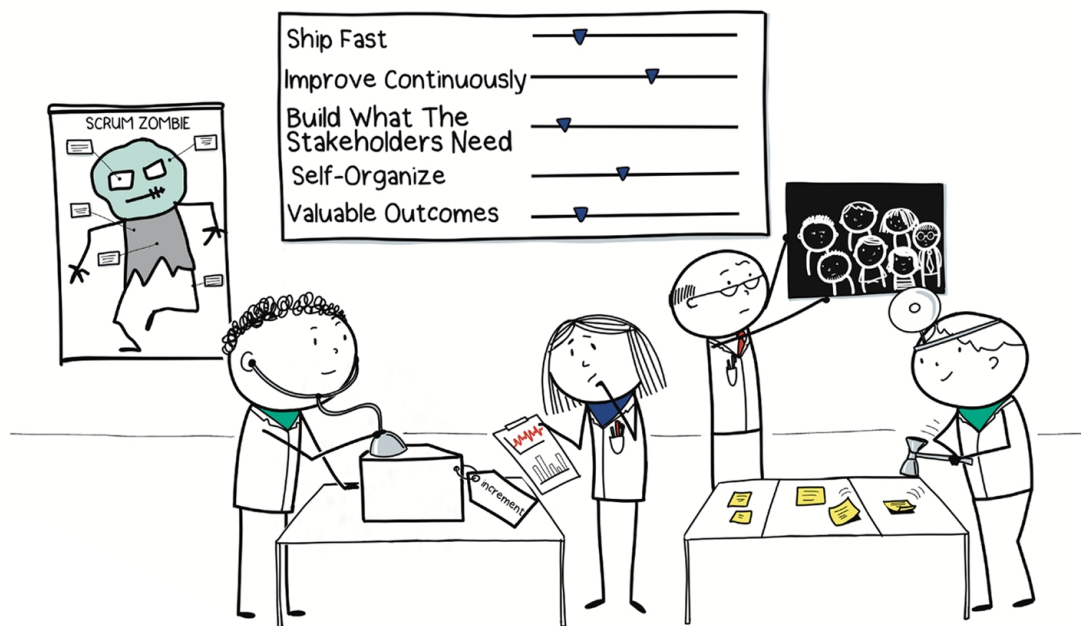
Superficial task-oriented conflicts aside, most of our conflicts with others begin where those social needs are violated by others — often unintentionally. And this is where the “pinches” (small issues and annoyances) begin. As the pinches continue to build, it eventually results in a crunch, which means the end of a relationship, partnership, or collaboration.

We created this do-it-yourself workshop to make you aware of the Pinch Model for Conflict (Sherwood & Scherer, 1975). It helps you see how conflict builds over time, and how clarifying roles and expectations can help navigate them.

Give it a try, and share the results!

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators



Created by Theo Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Scharlau & Barry Overeem
zombiescrum.org

Flow



Step 1: Opening

 3 min

Step 2: Identify Examples Of Tension With 1-2-4-ALL

  20 min

Step 3: Introduce The Pinch Model For Conflict

 15 min

Step 4: Share Success Stories With Appreciative Interviews

  40 min

Step 5: Identify Personal Next Steps

  10 min

Step 6: Closing

 2 min

Total duration

 90 min

Difficulty / Effort



Required Skill



We included fairly simple Liberating Structures to help you explore and experience the model.

Impact On Survival



Conflict decreases team productivity and safety, so it's important to learn its origins.



How To Prepare



Group Size

This string of Liberating Structures is feasible from 4 participants and onward.

Intended Audience

We designed this workshop for one Scrum team that wants to learn how conflict builds over time. It is possible to use it with multiple teams, stakeholders, or other people from the organization. You do need to pay attention to create an environment where everyone feels safe to practice and speak up.

Virtual Delivery

Liberating Structures work well virtually. Here too, they allow you to unleash and involve everyone. What is exceptionally important, however, is that you have the right tools. Because Liberating Structures are fundamentally about breaking down large-group interactions into smaller groups, you need tools that allow you to create subchannels or breakout rooms easily. [Zoom](#) is ideal for this, but similar features are available in tools like [Teams](#) and [GotoMeeting](#). We also recommend a virtual whiteboard where you can collect shared insights, like [Mural](#), [Miro](#), or [Google Slides](#). Even [Slack](#) can work.

Preparation

- Prepare slides or supporting materials for the various rounds and their invitations.
- A (virtual) poster with the Pinch Model of Conflict
- For in-person workshops, visualize the Pinch Model of Conflict with tape on the floor
- Optionally, a poster with the steps of [Conversation Cafe](#)

Resources

- Blog post by Christiaan Verwijs which was used as inspiration for this DIY workshop: [Navigating Conflict, A Lifetime Of Work](#)
- Blog post: [Address The Elephant](#)
- Podcast: [Conflict Styles, What Science Says & How Liberating Structures Can Help](#)

Credits



In November 2019, we hosted a 1-day workshop on navigating tension and conflict in groups with [Julie Huffaker](#) & [Karen Dawson](#) from Deeper Funnier Change and [Daniel Steinhöfer](#) from Holisticon. Attended by 55 participants, we explored how instead of 'resolving' conflict — which often isn't possible — we can navigate conflict and tension more productively instead.

This DIY workshop draws inspiration from the content and material we created together with Julie, Karen, and Daniel.



Step 1: Opening

Start at the scheduled time. People who drop in later can jump in then. We always start our gatherings by simply saying "Hi!", followed by our name. We then explain the purpose and start with the first structure. Superfast!

We've learned that the best way to drain energy is to talk for a long time, to ask everyone to introduce themselves, or to wait for people to drop in.

Step 2: Identify Examples Of Tension With 1-2-4-ALL

If you ask someone what "conflict" is, they usually explain it in terms of a verbal dispute, raised voices, slamming doors, and angry faces. But most of our conflicts are far less visible. They may not be explicitly expressed by those experiencing it, but they do influence the dynamics of a group. And either the whole group is aware of this, or some are. This is the proverbial 'Elephant In The Room'. And when you don't see them, or don't talk about them, it limits your ability as a team to grow and learn from them. It also means that valuable energy is siphoned into a conflict, instead of working together.

In this step, the Liberating Structure [1-2-4-ALL](#) is used to help the group gain their first thoughts and ideas on how they recognize the 'Elephant in the room'. What do they observe in themselves or in others?

Below we shared examples of 'Elephants In The Room'. You could consider these also as 'pinches'. I wouldn't introduce the 'Pinch Model for Conflict' yet, but it's good to understand the connection.

Invitation

"How do you know when tension is present – what do you notice or observe in yourself and in the team?"

Steps

1.  Ask everyone to first individually and in silence reflect on the invitation and write down what comes to mind.
2.  Invite people into pairs to share their ideas and build on them together. If you do this virtually, create breakout rooms for the pairs.
3.  Ask the pairs to find another pair and share their ideas, and how they built on them, again building on their ideas in a group of four. If you're doing this virtually, move the groups of four into break-out rooms.
4.  Together, collect the key ideas in a shared workspace.

Our Findings

- 1-2-4-ALL is purposefully quick. Even though people may individually struggle to generate much, the group as a whole will. You can always do a second 1-2-4-ALL if you need to go deeper.
- Facilitate the silent self-reflection firmly, before the paired conversations, and invite everyone to write down their ideas. This allows participants to focus and make ideas tangible and specific.

Types Of Elephants

- A 'blame game' where one person or group feels they are unsuccessful because they are not getting what they need from others; while others, in turn, believe the person or group is not succeeding because of a lack of commitment or skill;
- A group or person claims 'most of the air time' by going on and on about something they think or feel, while others

are bothered by that and remain silent or don't share what they really think or feel;

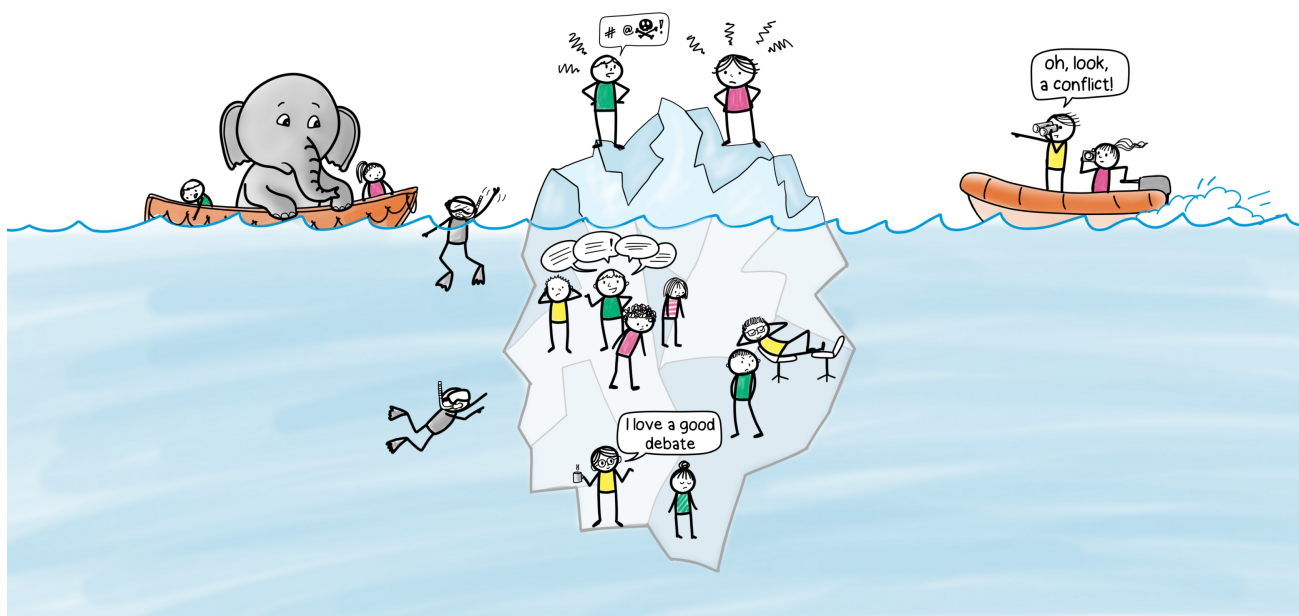
- Acts of 'sabotage', where one person or group actively or passively obstructs another person or group from achieving their goal, for example by not showing up for meetings or collaboration opportunities;
- 'Stepping on each other's toes' due to a lack of clarity in how roles and responsibilities are distributed or because people are "not stepping up" according to some, and the resulting frustration from that;
- There is the perception that a person or a group is 'not taking responsibility' for a decision or is 'free-riding' on the success of others; Because the system can't see itself, everyone feels that they are 'contributing a bigger share' or working harder than the others;
- People or groups feel that others are 'not fully honest' about their motives;
- People or groups 'bask in the light' of someone they hold in high esteem, like a CEO or a manager, while others feel neglected, unheard or unseen by this person;
- People or groups have different ideas on how to move forward, while also being frustrated by the inability of others to see their point of view (a task conflict);

One common theme is that many conflicts are essentially about our relative status in a group. Specifically, when we feel our status is lowered because others don't value us or our contributions. When there is disharmony in the social hierarchy, this causes strong emotional responses — like frustration, anger, fear, shame, sadness, or anxiety — in those experiencing the disharmony. It's a good example of how our primate brains evolved to value social hierarchies and our position in them.

Another characteristic is that conflicts are often unilateral, in that they are experienced by one party but not the others. This also depends on our personal beliefs; what one person perceives as an attack on personal status may be perceived by another as a 'good and productive debate'.

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- Blog post: Engage Everyone Simultaneously in Generating Questions, Ideas, and Suggestions with [1-2-4-ALL](#)



Step 3: Introduce The Pinch Model For Conflict

In the previous step, the group identified examples of how they recognize tension in themselves and in the team. This is a good moment to introduce the Pinch Model for Conflict and to make the group aware of how it helps you see how conflict builds over time, and how clarifying roles and expectations can help navigate them.

Steps

- **10 min** Introduce the Pinch Model For Conflict. Draw inspiration from the text we've included below. Ideally, make every step more concrete with a real-life example. With an in-person workshop, draw the model with tape on the floor, and literally walk through the model together with the group.
- **5 min** Answer questions that need clarification before the group moves into the next step, Conversation Cafe.

The Pinch Model For Conflict

Most collaborations begin with a honeymoon. We have big ideas, see fields of possibilities, and are eager to get started. The "pinches" begin as our expectations and social needs are violated, as is only natural in any human interaction. A pinch can take the form of someone going on and on, leaving no space for your valuable contribution. It can also take the shape of feeling like you're doing more than others. Or when others bask in the light of someone of high status, and you are not. We shared many of these invisible pinches earlier in this DIY workshop. Wanting to keep things positive and fun, and not wanting to be seen as 'that person that always complains', we swallow our tiny hurts and step over them.

But as the pinches continue to build, eventually there is a CRUNCH. Stronger emotions soar and turn into resentment, anger, and blame. Although it is possible to return back to the honeymoon from a crunch through mediation and open and frank conversations, the process is often difficult and painful (and thus requires a big investment from both parties). "Crunches" account for a large percentage of absenteeism, for people leaving teams or breaking up collaborations.

The Pinch Model for Conflict was originally developed and used for couple relationships. However, it's useful to use in professional relationships as well. It helps us see how conflict builds over time, and how clarifying roles and expectations can help navigate them. This model and other scientific research tell us unambiguously that addressing pinches early, as well as re-negotiating expectations and roles, is the best way to navigate conflict. It also is an unavoidable part of any collaboration, as implicit expectations and needs are violated by others.

References

- The illustration is created by Julie Huffaker and Karen Dawson from DeeperFunner
- Sherwood, J.J., & Scherer, J.J. (February, 1975). A model for couples: How two can grow together. Journal for small group behavior.
- Article "[Are You Using the Pinch Theory Of Conflict Management?](#)"



PINCH THEORY

BREAKUP

Crunch

seriously damages
relationship

- Anxiety
- Resentment
- Blaming

TOXICITY

- Uncertainty
- Uneasiness

- Share information
- Clarify expectations

- Role clarity
- Commitment

HONEYMOON

- Stability
- Productivity
- Confidence

Pinch

disrupts shared
expectations

- Adapted from John J. Sherwood, John C. Gildewell, and John Scherer



Step 4: Share Success Stories With Appreciative Interviews

At this point, the group has identified ideas on how to recognize tension in themselves and in the team, and you've introduced the Pinch Model For Conflict. Dealing with conflict is tough. For many people, it causes stress, tension, and it makes them anxious. But we're confident, that everyone has had successful moments of navigating conflict as well. This is where the Liberating Structure [Appreciative Interviews](#) comes into play. It is a great way to identify what drives success and triggers insights for positive change by uncovering hidden success stories. It brings a positive mindset, makes personal connections, and puts people in a positive frame of mind.



Invitation

"In pairs, share a story of a time when you navigated tension and/or conflict, and you're proud of how it turned out."

Steps

1. **2 min** Explain the sequence of steps upfront so that people know they will be sharing a story, listening to another story, and then re-telling the story they listened to.
2. **2 min** Give participants a few minutes to silently bring back into memory a success story from their past, or at least the start of it.
3. **8 min** Invite pairs into their own breakouts. In turn (4 min each), people interview each other about the success story of the other while paying attention to what made the success possible. The interviewer only asks questions (no advice, suggestions, etc.).
4. **12 min** Invite pairs to join another pair in new breakouts. Everyone retells the story of the person they interviewed. The other three participants listen for patterns in conditions/assets that supported the success. Invite groups to capture the most salient factors in your virtual whiteboard.
5. **4 min** When everyone is back in the main channel, collect insights from the group. Ask people to share some examples of what created the insights for them. The purpose here is not to collect everything, but mostly to spread ideas around. So don't let this go on and on.
6. **4 min** Ask: "What was made possible by sharing our stories in this manner?". Invite people to silently reflect on this individually (1 minute) and then together.

Our findings

- We often encourage people to channel a journalist that they admire or frequently read articles from in the newspaper. Frequently, this makes people ask deeper questions.

Resources

- Blog post: [Discovering and Building on the Root Causes of Success with Appreciative Interviews](#)
- The original article on [Appreciative Interviews](#) on the website of Liberating Structures

Step 5: Identify Personal Next Steps

With Appreciative Interviews, everyone shared a story on how they've successfully navigated tension and/or conflict. By sharing all these stories, the group also identified the key success factors of dealing with tension. In the closing step of this workshop, everyone is asked to individually identify their personal next steps.

Invitation

"When you take the success factors of navigating conflict into account, what is your personal 15% Solution to address conflict more effectively?"



Steps

1. **3 min** Ask everyone to silently generate a list of personal 15% Solutions.
2. **5 min** Form pairs and invite each pair into their own breakouts. In the breakouts, people take turns to share their 15% Solutions. We always encourage listeners to help their partner find a way to guarantee that they will actually do those things (e.g. make it smaller, simpler).
3. **2 min** When everyone is together, ask people to add their 15% Solutions to a shared workspace and briefly mention what they intend to do.

Our Findings

- It is tempting for people to complicate their 15% Solutions, which makes it unlikely they'll actually do them. You can encourage people by asking them "What is the thing you're going to do to work on that [original idea]?"

Resources

- The original article on [15% Solutions](#) on the Liberating Structures website
- Blog post: Trigger BIG change by starting small with ["15% Solutions"](#)

Step 6: Closing

With this workshop, you made the team aware of the Pinch Model for Conflict and helped them see how conflict builds over time, and how clarifying roles and expectations can help navigate them.

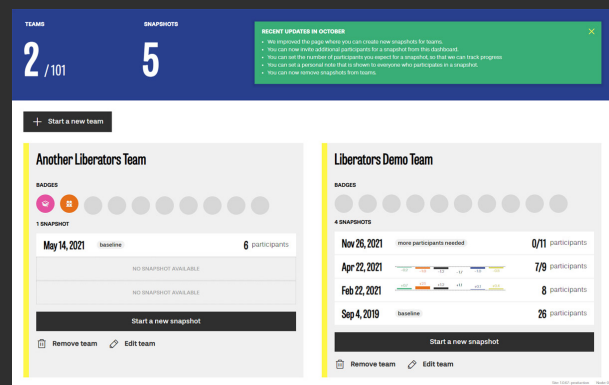
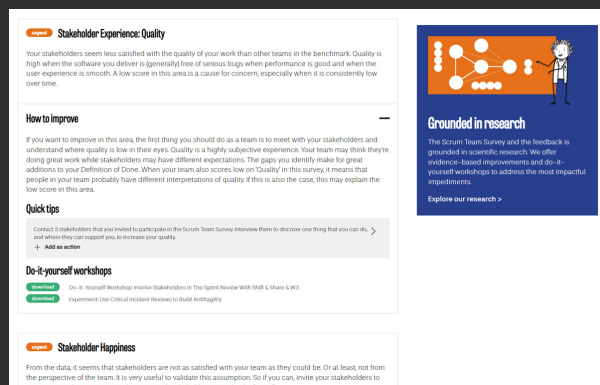
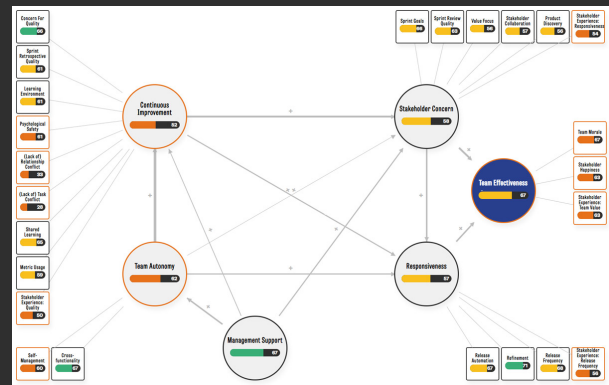
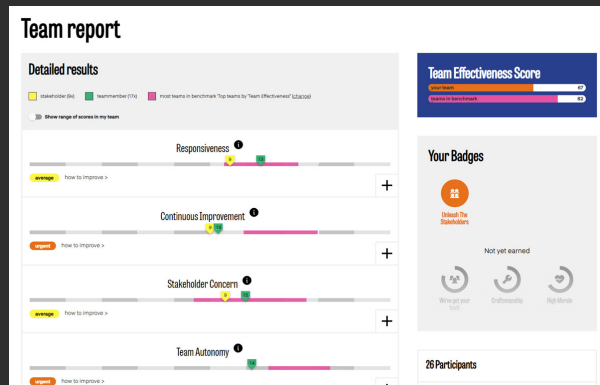
If you've got any questions, comments, or ideas: always feel free to reach out and share them with us.

Let's learn and grow, together!



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	Essential	Liberator
Invite team members & stakeholders	unlimited	unlimited
Quick Tips for your team per topic	3	unlimited
Recommendations to your team	5	unlimited
Compare your team against different benchmarks		✓
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